

UNDERSTANDING AYATOLLAH RUHULLAH AL-MUSAVI KHOMEINI'S POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION AND ULTIMATE REALITY

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Brief Biography

Sayyid Ruhollah Musavi Khomeini was born on 17th May 1900 and died on 3rd June 1989, also known as **Ayatollah Khomeini**, was an Iranian political and religious leader who served as the first supreme leader of Iran from 1979 after the revolution he inspired and led, until his death in 1989. In the official identity (data considered to be given by his brother) Khomeini was born on September 24th 1902, which in Islamic calendar was the 20th of *Jumad*, which in turn has great Significance as the birth date of Fatma the wife of Abu Bakr Umar ibn al-Khattab, Shi'ite Islam's first Imam or Caliph, and the daughter of Prophet Muhammad.

He was the founder of the Islamic Republic of Iran and the leader of the 1979 Iranian Revolution, which saw the overthrow of Shah Mohammad Reza Pahlavi and the end of the Persian hereditary monarchy. Following the revolution, Khomeini became the country's first supreme leader, a position created in the constitution of the Islamic Republic as the highest-ranking political and religious authority of the nation, which he held with great success until his death. Although most of his period in power was taken up by the Iran–Iraq War of 1980–1988, under his leadership Iran took great strides in economic, academic and political independence. His unique approach to political rule, which was based on philosophic-religious foundation, has given reason to both admiration, controversy as well as hostility. He was succeeded by [Ali Khamenei](#), both in political position and ideological perpetuation, on 4th June 1989. This paper is a philosophic approach to the understanding of his political philosophy, both as a person, great family man, cultural defender, law giver, religious and political leader.

1. Background and Philosophic-religious Formation

Khomeini was born in Khomeyn, in what is now Iran's Markazi Province. His father was murdered in 1903 when Khomeini was two years old. Khomeini's maternal grandfather, Syed Ahmad Ali Musavi al-Hindi, an Islamic scholar, was a descendant of Imam Musa al Kazem, the seventh Imam; he was called al-Hindi-the Indian, because he was born in the northern Indian princely state of Oudh, where his forefathers had moved from Iran at the invitation of the Shi'ite king.¹ Khomeini's father, Mustafa al-Musavi, was chief clergyman of the town, shot dead in a road ambush for championing the cause of tenant farmers.

¹ Cf. Hiro, 1985, p. 376.

After the death of his father, the upbringing of the then 5-month-old Ruhullah fell on the shoulders of his mother and an aunt, both of whom died by the time he was 16. Ruhullah began to study the Qur'an and elementary Persian at the age of six. The following year, he began to attend a local school, where he learned religion, *noheh khani* (lamentation recital), and other traditional subjects. Throughout his childhood, he continued his religious education with the assistance of his relatives as we are going to see below, including his mother's cousin, Ja'far, and his elder brother, Murtuza Pasandideh, who came to be known as his guardian parent and friend.²

He therefore came increasingly under the care and guidance of his elder brother, Syed Murtuza, also a mullah (clergyman), who was famously known as *Ayatullah Pasandideh* - literally, the much-liked - who later in an interview with journalists in 1979, after the Iranian Islamic revolution, recalls: "I was older than Ruhullah but he was always wiser." Ruhullah grew up therefore in a family of strict religious observance and received strong intellectual and moral upbringing.

When he was 19 years old, he was sent to Arak, a seminary of Shaikh Abd al-Hakim Hairi, a famous scholar from a noted house of ayatullahs with a tradition of political activism. Hairi had been a pupil of Ayatullah Mirza Hasan Shirazi, who had led the 1891-92 protest against the monopoly on the production and marketing of tobacco in Iran to a British capitalist, Baron Paul Julius de Reuter. "Use of tobacco is tantamount to war against the Imam of the Age," Shirazi had declared, calling for nation-wide boycott of tobacco - which proved so total the king was forced to cancel the concession.³

In 1921, a year after Khomeini had joined Arak seminary, Hairi moved his *howza* (seminary) to Qum, which was the traditional center of Shi'ite learning, where Ruhullah grew up and married the daughter of a mullah. At his wedding date he was 25, and his wife Khadijah, who shared the name of the first wife of the Prophet was 14. Khomeini's studies included Islamic law (*sharia*) and jurisprudence (*fiqh*), but by that time, Khomeini had also acquired an interest in poetry and philosophy (*irfan*), which included Islamic ethics (*akhlaaq*). So, upon arriving in Qom, Khomeini sought the guidance of Mirza Ali Akbar Yazdi, a scholar of philosophy and mysticism. Yazdi died in 1924, but Khomeini continued to pursue his interest in philosophy with two other teachers, Javad Aqa Maleki Tabrizi and Rafi'i Qazvini. Many Khomein's biographers think that, perhaps Khomeini's biggest influences were another teacher,

² Cf. Milani 1994, p. 85.

³ Cf. M. HAROON SIDDIQUI, (May 27th 2022) Ayatollah Ruhullah al-Musavi Khomeini's Ultimate Reality and Meaning , downloaded from: <https://www.utpjournals.press/doi/pdf/10.3138/uram.9.2.117>. P. 118.

Mirza Muhammad 'Ali Shahabadi, and a variety of historic Sufi mystics, including Mulla Sadra and Ibn Arabi. Those subjects he was soon teaching and publishing, his first publication being an Arabic treatise on, *Misbah al Hidayah* (The Lamp of Guidance). This publication he gave before he turned 27.⁴ This marked Khomeini's struggle for the course he believed and was convinced to be right, namely the defense of God's law and the weak of the society.

His years in Qum coincided with the rise and fall of Reza Kahn, the Irani Cossack Colonel, who rose to the power of Shah and transformed the Iranian monarchy 'into a dictatorship of the modern, totalitarian kind whose chief domestic aim became the elimination of Islam as a political, social and cultural force, or secularization of the society⁵. In his desire to Europeanize Iran, Reza emulated Kamal Atatürk in neighboring Turkey who, through his 1925 hat law, had imposed death penalty on men wearing the traditional *fez cap*. In 1928 Reza had proclaimed the Uniform Dress law, banning the *hijab* or *chador*, (the Islamic scarf), later he banned the Shi'ite passion plays, and even the pilgrimage to Mecca; and in 1934 he changed the name of Persia to Iran the name that originated with other names like Aryan. Khomein, who was now an Islamic scholar condemned all these acts, both in his writings and teachings, thus forming a group of royal followers out of his students and fellow teachers.

Khomeini studied Greek philosophy and was influenced by both the philosophy of Aristotle, whom he regarded as the founder of logic, and Plato, whose views "in the field of divinity" he regarded as "grave and solid", and after which his system of political organization came to be patterned almost verbatim. Among Islamic philosophers, Khomeini was mainly influenced by Ibn Sina (Persian: 980 – June 1037 CE; ابن سینا), a Polymath commonly known in the West as Avicenna, who was the famous commentator of the works of Aristotle and discussed extensively the concepts of body and soul, which are the subjects of modern philosophical anthropology. Another Muslim scholar who had great influence of Khomein's thinking was Mulla Sadra.⁶

2. Teacher and Critique

Ruhullah Khomeini became a lecturer when he was 27 years of age, and started his career at Najaf and Qom seminaries for decades before he was known on the national

⁴ Cf. Hiro, 1985, p. 50.

⁵ Cf. Algar, 1981, p. 4.

⁶ Encyclopædia Britannica. "Ruhollah Khomeini – Britannica Online Encyclopedia". Britannica.com. Retrieved 19 March 2010.

political scene. Very fast he became a leading scholar of Shia Islam.⁷ He taught political philosophy, Islamic history and ethics. Several of his students – for example, Morteza Motahhari – later became leading Islamic philosophers and also *marja'*. As a scholar and teacher, Khomeini produced numerous writings on Islamic philosophy, law, and ethics.⁸ He showed an exceptional interest in subjects like philosophy and mysticism that not only were usually absent from the curriculum of Islamic seminaries but were often an object of hostility and suspicion.

Inaugurating his teaching career at the age of 27 by giving private lessons on *irfan* and the ideas of Mulla Sadra to a private circle, around the same time, in 1928, he also released his first publication, *Sharh Du'a al-Sahar* (Commentary on the Du'a al-Baha), "a detailed commentary, in Arabic, on the prayer recited before dawn during Ramadan by Imam Ja'far al-Sadiq", followed, some years later, by *Sirr al-Salat* (Secret of the Prayer), where "the symbolic dimensions and inner meaning of every part of the prayer, from the ablution that precedes it to the *salaam* that concludes it, are expounded in a rich, complex, and eloquent language that owes much to the concepts and terminology of Ibn 'Arabi.

As Sayyid Fihri, the editor and translator of *Sirr al-Salat*, has remarked, the work is addressed only to the foremost among the spiritual elite (*akhass-i khavass*) and establishes its author as one of their number."⁹ The second book has been translated by Sayyid Amjad Hussain Shah Naqavi and released by BRILL in 2015, under the title "The Mystery of Prayer: The Ascension of the Wayfarers and the Prayer of the Gnostics Archived 6 July 2017 at the Wayback Machine".

3. His Political Philosophy (*Wilâyat al-Faqîh*)

To be able to understand the political philosophy of Ayatollah Khomeini one must have a clear understanding of the concept of *velayat-e faqih* (in Farsi), or *Wilâyat al-Faqîh* (in Arabic) which refers to political ideology that transfers all political and religious authority to the Shia clergy and makes all of the state's key decisions subject to approval by a supreme clerical leader, the *vali-e faqih* (guardian Islamic jurist).¹⁰ This is a political ideology similar to the Middle Ages Christedoms of the European papal kingdoms, where at the top most peak of the pyramid was the *pontefix maximus*-the pope, who retained the right of decision of all important religious, social, political and cultural decisions. It was a replica of the Platonic

⁷ "BBC – History – Ayatollah Khomeini (1900–1989)". BBC. 4 June 1989. Retrieved 19 March 2010.

⁸Cf. Encyclopædia Britannica. "Ruhollah Khomeini – Britannica Online Encyclopedia". Britannica.com. Retrieved 19 March 2010.

⁹ ERVAND ABRAHAMIAN, *Islam, Politics, and Social Movements*, University of California Press (1988), p. 269

¹⁰ What Is Velayat-e Faqih? - Institute for Global Change<https://institute.global/policy/what-velayat-e-faqih>

Republic ruled by a group of philosophic elites under the guidance of the sage Plato called Philosopher King.

Before we discuss further the concept of *wilâyat al-faqîh*, let us first review a number of concepts that cannot be separated from this concept. These concepts include the concept of *Imamate*, the concept of purpose of the state, and the concept of sovereignty. The concept of 'Imamate' etymologically is derived from the word 'amma', which means to go towards, or go to see. The concept of Imamate among the Shi'ites is understood as divinely position chosen by God for His servants from His preexisting knowledge by which God has chosen someone as His prophet.

The God commanded the Prophet to appoint a successor and ordered his followers to follow the appointment. Shiites believe that Allah commanded the Prophet to appoint Ali ibn Abi Talib, as a guide and mentor for Muslims. Furthermore, Kâsyif al-Githa explains that God is never empty the earth of a proof (*hujjah*) of His servants, whether it is a prophet or a *washi*, clearly or even unseen. The Holy Prophet Muhammed has contended 'Ali as a *washi*, and he willed to his son, al-Hasan, and al-Hasan willed his brother al-Husain, and so on until the Twelfth leader (the *Imam Mahdi*, whose presence is waited at the end of time.¹¹

2.1 The Imamate Theory

The Imamate theory states that the authority and sovereignty of the state is the prerogative of Allah, and then Allah delegates His rights to the Prophet. After the Prophet's death, the rights are transferred to the twelfth imam. When the twelfth imam is undergoing major occultation, then the authority (*wilayat*) of Imam was submitted to the intellectually and spiritually qualified jurist (*al-syarâ'ith jam'i*) as the representative of him, until the imam comes back to the world.¹²

Therefore, the guardianship of the jurist is legalized and his authority is associated with the God's original and absolute authority. The authority of the *imam* is explicitly established by the Prophet, while the *Faqih* (jurist) gained the authority from the twelfth *Imam*, based on specific qualifications such as justice and broad knowledge of Islamic law. On this basis, the continuity of leadership from the days of the Prophet, the Imams, to the *faqih* is a religiously necessary succession in order to maintain and implement *sharia* in the life of Islamic community and to realize the happiness in the world and the life after death.

¹¹Cf. MUHAMMAD HUSAIN AL-KÂSYIF AL-GITHÂ, *Ashl al-Syi'ah wa Ushûluha*, (Iran: Matktab al-Tsaqâfah allislâmiyyah

¹² MUHAMMAD HUSAIN AL-KÂSYIF AL-GITHA, *Ashl al-Syi'ah wa Ushûluha* (Teheran: Matktab al-Tsaqâfah allislâmiyyah, t.t.). p. 136.

The theory of Imamate therefore generates some elements of Shiite leadership theory. 1. The theory of *al-luthf*. This theory explains that Allah with His affectionate ('al-lutf) may not allow a community without a leader (*Imam*) who will be responsible of managing religious, social and political affairs. 2. The theory of *al-'adl*. This theory reveals that the life of human being in the world will run fairly if it is accompanied by His messengers to guide them to the right path, because the human's mind is sometimes influenced by the passions that drive him to the wrong way. 3. The theory of *al-Salah wa al-Ashlah*. This theory explains that God, with His graciousness and His mercifulness, has responsibility of doing His best for the benefit of His creatures in the world¹³. Therefore, the leadership of the people should be kept by those who have noble qualities and superior (*al-Afdhal*), ie 'Ali ibn Abi Talib and eleven descendants.¹⁴ Because the twelfth Imam is in major occultation, then a qualified jurist becomes his successors.

According to modern political terminology, 'caliphate' or 'Imamate' is synonymous with 'state', because the two terms are substantially relying on the country's sovereignty in order to achieve the desired goals of the people. Similarly, in the Islamic studies these terms mean the Caliphate, Imamate, *hukûmah*, *daulah*, and the sultanates. The term of 'imamate' refers to a state in Islamic studies. Munawir Sjadzali as cited by al-Mawardi said that the priest (*imam*) was caliph, king, sultan or head of state (this should not be confused with the Roman Catholic three *mundus* {offices} of the baptized: Prophet, priest and King, as the three offices inherited from Jesus by every baptized person). This generic term (imamate) is acceptable to all Muslims, whether Sunni, or Shia¹⁵.

The second concept that cannot be separated from the concept of *wilâyat alfaqîh* is the concept of the state's purpose. In Islamic thought, this concept, at least, is suggested by some clerics (*ulama*), among others *Ibn Abi Râbî'i*, *al-Mawardi*, *Ibn Khaldun*, and *Ibn Taimiya*.

Ibn Rabi'i, suggests that the purpose of the establishment of a state is to enable people to run their lives well away from the dispute, and to prevent intervention of foreign parties. Al-Mawardi states that it aims to replace prophetic roles in order to

¹³ Cf. HAMID ENAYAT, *Reaksi Politik Sunni dan Syi'ah: Pemikiran Islam Modern Menghadapi Abad ke-20*, (Bandung: Pustaka, 1982). pp. 56-57.

¹⁴ MUHAMMAD ABÛ ZAHRAH, *USHÛL AL-FIQH*, (Kairo: Dâr al-Fikr al-'Arabi, 1985), 277-278, See also, M. Khalid Masood, *Islamic Legal Philosophy: A Study of Abû Ishâq al-Syâthibî Life and Thought* (New Delhi: International Islamic Publishers, 1989), p.149.

¹⁵ MUNAWIR SJADZALI, *ISLAM DAN TATA NEGARA: Ajaran, Sejarah dan Pemikiran* (Jakarta: Universitas Indonesia Press, 1990), pp. 42-45.

maintain and manage the world¹⁶. He, further, said that the state through its agencies has six common goals: (a) to maintain the religion; (b) to maintain the rights of the people and the laws of God; (c) to implement the rule of law between the disputing parties, and promote universal justice; (d) to protect the region and maintain the honor of the people of Islam; (e) to do the holy war (jihad) against those who oppose Islam; and (f) to establish a military force to confront the enemy¹⁷. It is important to bear in mind that the concept of *wilâyat alfaqîh* presupposes a homogeneous Islamic society.

Meanwhile, Ibn Khaldun states that the purpose of establishing a state is to seek and realize the benefit of religion and the world that lead to the interest of the hereafter,¹⁸ while according to al-Ghazali, it is to implement Islamic law, to realize the benefit of the people, and to ensure order of world and religious affairs¹⁹. In addition, Ibn Taimiya states that it is to implement Islamic law in a comprehensive way, to realize the welfare of the people, and to promote justice and trust in the community²⁰. A society that is composed mostly of moslems, could not be guided but by this kind of holistic political set up.

Important to all the views of the above quoted Islamic scholars is that, the state fulfils the purpose of religion, and hence becomes subject to it. This fits perfectly in the idea that God becomes the supreme leader of the society, and hence the theocracy functions smoothly in the Islamic society, like Iran. In other words, in Islam set-up politics is not an Architectonic art, as Aristotle would put it; it is a handmaid of religion; since the later is the will of God on earth. It is for that reason that in an imamate politicians operate under the direction or guidance of a religious expert, who represents the will of God. In that way the following concept of sovereignty becomes very meaningful to the society, especially a society that had been under hereditary dynastic rule.

2.2 The concept of Sovereignty

¹⁶ Cf. AL-MÂWARDI, *al-Ahkâm al-Sulthâniyyah* ..., p. 5.

¹⁷ Cf. AL-MÂWARDI, *al-Ahkâm al-Sulthâniyyah*..., p. 5, see also Qomaruddin Khan, *Al-Mâwardi's Theory of State* ..., pp.61-68.

¹⁸ Cf. ABD AL-RAHMÂN IBN KHALDUN, *al-Muqaddimah*, (Mesir: Musthafâ Muhammad, t.t), p. 124

¹⁹ Cf. J. SAYUTHI PULUNGAN, *Fiqh Siyasah: Ajaran, Sejarah dan Pemikiran*, (Jakarta: PT Rajawali Press, 1997), p. 260.

²⁰ IBNU TAYMIYYAH, *al-Siyâsah al-Syar'iyyah fî Ishlâh al-Râ'i wa al-Ra'iyyah*, (Kair o: Dâr al-Kâtib al-'Arabi, t.t.), pp.29-30.

The next concept which is also strongly associated with the concept of *wilâyat al-faqîh* is the concept of sovereignty. Sovereignty as the supreme authority in the country has been known since ancient Greece. It can be seen from the statement of Aristotle that “the government is everywhere sovereign in the state, and the constitution as the supreme authority in the state, must be in the hands of one, or a few, or the many. And, indeed for Aristotle “constitutions which aim at the common advantage are correct and just without qualification, whereas those which aim only at the advantage of the rulers are deviant and unjust, because they involve despotic rule which is inappropriate for a community of free persons”²¹. Khomein took this statement very seriously and hence his political philosophy was aimed at the advantage of the people.

G.H. Sabine describes the concept of sovereignty by arguing that sovereignty is not limited by law since the king has become a source of law. The king is not accountable to its people, but is responsible to God and submits to the laws of nature.. In a further development, the doctrine of absolute power did not last. The sovereignty owned by a king is limited by constitution, even in a democratic country; the sovereignty is on the people hands. Regarding the sovereignty, there are theories that are relevant to the sovereign (ruler) of state. They are the theory of state sovereignty resources and the theory about the legitimacy of power. The former is divided into four sections, namely: (1) the theory of the sovereignty of God, (2) the theory of the sovereignty of the state, (3) the theory of people sovereignty, (4) the theory of sovereignty of law. And the later includes the three theories, namely: (1) the theory of the divine, (2) the theory of power, (3) the theory of social contract. All these reflections were taken from Plato and Aristotle, as the inspirer of Khomeini’s political mind, with addition of some renaissance and modern philosophers like Thomas Hobbes and John Lock.

2.2.1 The Theory of Sovereignty of God

This theory asserts that God has the sovereignty of the state. All events in the universe occur because of God’s will and guidance, including the existence of state. God appointed a person among men who is under the power of the state to supervise and execute the law of God. The leader acts on behalf of God to rule the world and the country. According to this theory, a country would not have existed if God did not want it. This doctrine was derived from the Scholastic philosophy²² and some are derived from religious teachings. For Khomeini in a historical perspective of the

²¹ . *Politics*, 1279a17–21.

²² Khomeini studied Avicenna, and other scholastic philosophers, including St. Thomas Aquinas and St. Augustine, both of whom constitute the political thought of Islamic Iran, mixed with Koranic ideas of political organization.

government as well as the (mediaeval) church itself is an absolute monarchy since it is regarded from *al-Masih*, who served as a source of law in the state political life of the Christendom. The main character of this is St. Augustine. According to him, the God state is based on God's love (the city of God). God's love that is immortal is the glue that integrates the factors into a unified political entity, and it is inseparable because they come from God, who is the author of every reality.

2.2.2 Theory of State Sovereignty

This theory teaches that the ultimate power is held by the state (as the collective will of the people), so the state should determine the law, people obey the law because it is the will of the state (just as they would obey themselves). In the daily practice of life, the sovereignty is in the hands of kings, as it was known in European continent in the sixteenth century until the seventeenth century. The king had absolute power to make laws for the people. He is not bound by laws that restrict them from outside except by God's law of natural law, because the kings considered themselves the owner of a full power so they have right from God to make any laws. The doctrine of state sovereignty laid by Jean Bodin in the field of political philosophy, and Thomas Hobbes (1588-1679), who is also one of the founder of the theory of the social contract that establishes the state as a social coercive force that cannot be resisted by citizens, who brought it into being.

2.2.3 Theory of Sovereignty of the People

Based on this theory, the supreme power of the country belongs to the people. The will of the people in form of public will is the basis of state power. The government is the representative of the people to realize the good and the common prosperity. Government that acts in accordance with the will of the people can be replaced with a new government in accordance with the choice of the majority. This doctrine is a reaction to the theory of state sovereignty and is relevant to the theory proposed by John Locke (1632-1704) and Jean Rousseau (1712-1778)²³.

2.2.4 Theory of Sovereignty of the Law

The theory was developed by Hugo Krabbe (1857-1936) in his *Die Lehre Der Rechtssouveranitat* and later by his disciple, R. Karenburg in his work *Algemene Statsleer* (1937)²⁴. Krabbe states that the law which has the highest authority in the state. All the activities of state agencies and other political tools should be based on

²³ The two philosophers are hailed as the Fathers of European Republican democracy, and Khomein take these ideas from the Political philosophic writings of those thinkers.

and limited by law, so that this theory generates the concept of the legal state. Indeed, the law sovereignty has been found in the political thought of Aristotle²⁵. In a modern political system, political power is not concentrated in one institution, but scattered and distributed to other institutions in accordance with its function in the administration of the state. The distribution of political power can be seen from two aspects. First is the division of powers between central government agencies and local governments, which are more quantitative. And second, the division of power among institutions of high-level state associated with state functions, which is qualitative.

Technically, quantitative distribution is called a power-sharing, and a qualitative division called separation of powers. The idea of sharing and separating power are found in political thought in the 17th, and 18th century, as proposed by John Locke and Montesquieu (1689-1755). Montesquieu's idea is known as the theory of *Trias Politica* which has a great influence in the world. This theory teaches that the power of the state consists of three kinds of power, namely: (i) the legislative power, (rulemaking function), (ii) executive powers (rule application function), and (iii) the judicial power (adjudication function). This theory is a normative principle that the powers (functions) should not be given to the same people to prevent the abuse of power in order that the citizen's rights are more secure and protected.

4. Khomeini's Ultimate Reality and Mysticism

Ayatollah Khomeini lived his academic and spiritual conviction that the Government must be religious and must be the custodian of religious values. Since his seminary teaching, which often focused on the importance of religion to practical social and political issues of the day, he worked against secularism in the 1940s. Always he was planning and contemplating his political concept of *Wilayat al faqih*, which later he came to implement perfectly in the Iranian Constitution. His first political publication, *Kashf al-Asrar* (Uncovering of Secrets) published in 1942, was a point-by-point refutation of *Asrar-e hezar sale* (Secrets of a Thousand Years), a tract written by a disciple of Iran's leading anti-clerical historian, Ahmad Kasravi,²⁴ as well as a condemnation of innovations such as international time zones, and the banning of hijab by Reza Shah. In addition, he went from Qom to Tehran to listen to secular government derived from Nuri's objections to the 1907 constitution.²⁵

Ayatullah Hasan Mudarris, the leader of the opposition majority in Iran's parliament during the 1920s. Khomeini became a *marja'* in 1963, following the death of Grand

²⁴Cf. Cohen 2009, p. 15.

²⁵ STEPHEN C. POULSON (2006). *Social Movements in Twentieth-Century Iran: Culture, Ideology, and Mobilizing Frameworks*. Lexington Books. p. 159. ISBN 978-0-7391-1757-6.

Ayatollah Seyyed Husayn Borujerdi. Khomeini also valued the ideals of Islamists such as Sheikh Fazlollah Noori and Abol-Ghasem Kashani. Khomeini saw Fazlollah Nuri as a "heroic figure", and his own objections to constitutionalism and a secular government derived from Nuri's objections to the 1907 constitution. Khomeini's objection to constitutionalism was not a blind undertaking, since he understood what constitutionalism amounted to, by looking at European states. The uniqueness of Iran's Constitution consists in being a theocratic constitution, having the law God as the reference.

Most Iranians had a deep respect for the Shi'a clergy or Ulama, and looking at his example tended to be religious, traditional, and alienated from the process of Westernization pursued by the Shah. In the late 19th century Iran the clergy had shown themselves to be a powerful political force in the Iranian society, initiating the Tobacco Protest against a concession to a foreign (British) interest, as indicated above.

When he reached the age of 61, Khomeini inherited the arena of leadership open due to the deaths of some notable religious activists. A series of religious leaders died, they included Ayatollah Sayyed Husayn Borujerdi (1961), who was the leading, although politically compromising, Shi'ah religious leader; and Ayatollah Abol-Ghasem Kashani (1962), a politically active cleric. Khomeini therefore came to join the clerical class that had been politically active ever since the 1920s when the secular, anti-clerical modernizer Reza Shah Pahlavi had come to power. Reza's son Mohammad Reza Shah, instituted a policy of modernization he named "White Revolution", which was a further challenge to the religious minded leaders, and which Ruhullah Khomeini resisted strongly in his teachings and activism.

5. Holistic Society and the Idea of Sovereignty.

Khomein's political Philosophy is holistic, in the sense that everything should be subjected to the Sovereignty of God, and the last decision must be done by the supreme religious leader. His constitutional preference was that of Aristotle, which was based on the people's sovereignty, although it was to be under the control of intellectuals, similar to the Platonic Philosopher kings. Plato's republic, though many times referred to as utopian state, was, in his philosophic mind, achievable and realistic. It came to be challenged and further explained by his student Aristotle, who still thought that the state to be realistically functional it must exist for the advantage of many, but be ruled by one individual, taking turns for each other's advantage.²⁶ The concept of justice is the leading principle of Iranian revolution, and that

²⁶ Cf. Politics, 1279a8-13.

Khomeini took from the Aristotelian Political philosophy, which has been tamed as the politics of the common good, or the politics of justice.

Aristotle's constitutional theory is based on his theory of justice, which is extensively explained in *Nicomachean Ethics* book V. Aristotle distinguishes two different but related senses of “justice” — universal and particular — both of which play an important role in his constitutional theory. Firstly, in the general sense “justice” means “lawfulness” or also called legal justice and is concerned with the common advantage and happiness of the political community.²⁷ The understanding of legal justice undergirds the distinction between correct (just) and deviant (unjust) constitutions. But what exactly the “common advantage” (*koinion sumpheron*) involves is a matter of scholarly debates in Political philosophy lectures. Some passages from Aristotle imply that justice involves the advantage of all the citizens; for example, every citizen of the best constitution has a just claim to private property and to a suitable education.²⁸ But Aristotle also allows that it might be “in a way” just to ostracize powerful citizens even when they have not been convicted of any crimes.²⁹ Whether Aristotle understands the common advantage as safeguarding the interests of each and every citizen has a bearing on whether he anticipates what modern thinkers would understand as a theory of individual rights.³⁰

Secondly, in the particular sense “justice” means “equality” or “fairness”, and this includes distributive justice, according to which different individuals have just claims to shares of some common asset such as property. Aristotle analyzes arguments for and against the different constitutions as different applications of the principle of distributive justice.³¹ Everyone agrees, he says, that justice involves treating equal persons equally, and treating unequal persons unequally, but they do not agree on the standard by which individuals are deemed to be equally (or unequally) meritorious or deserving. He assumes his own analysis of distributive justice set forth in *Nicomachean Ethics* V.3: Justice requires that benefits (and burdens) be distributed to individuals in proportion to their merit or desert.

The oligarchs mistakenly think that those who are superior in wealth should also have superior political rights, whereas the democrats hold that those who are equal in free birth should also have equal political rights. Both of these conceptions of political justice are mistaken in Aristotle's view, because they assume a false conception of the ultimate end of the city-state. Khomeini agrees completely to this view and adopts it to the Iranian constitution, which takes the concept of justice very

²⁷ Cf. NE V.1.1129b11–19; Politics. III.12.1282b16–17.

²⁸ Cf. Politics. VII.9.1329a23–4, 13.1332a32–8.

²⁹ Cf. III.13.1284b15–20.

³⁰ See Fred Miller and Richard Kraut for differing understanding of legal justice and individual rights.

³¹ Cf. NE. III.9.1280a7–22.

seriously. The city-state is neither a business enterprise to maximize wealth (as the oligarchs suppose) nor an association to promote liberty and equality (as the democrats maintain). Instead, Aristotle argues, “the good life is the end of the city-state,” that is, a life consisting of noble actions.³²

Hence, the correct conception of justice is aristocratic, assigning political rights to those who make a full contribution to the political community, that is, to those with virtue as well as property and freedom.³³ This is what Khomeini understands by Platonic and Aristotelian dictum of the rule of an “aristocratic” constitution: literally, the rule of the *aristoi*, i.e., best persons. Khomeini replaces the *aristoi*, with the Ulama, who are the enlightened of the society. Aristotle explores the implications of this argument in the remainder of *Politics* III, considering the rival claims of the rule of law and the rule of a supremely virtuous individual (compared here to Ayatollah of Khomeini’s rule). Here absolute kingship is a limiting case of aristocracy. Again, in books VII-VIII, Aristotle describes the ideal constitution in which the citizens are fully virtuous. Indeed Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini used his study of philosophy to build a religious republic based on Philosophical principles and solid religious convictions.

6. Philosophical Appraisal and Khomeini’s vindication

Is there any comparison between the Imamate and Christendom of medieval Christianity? Yes, indeed the model of Christendom of the medieval Europe inspired Imam Khomeini to come up with a modernized Islamic state that has withstood the test of time. The Christendom of the medieval Europe was modeled after the Philosopher King rule of Plato, under the principle of participation and oneness of a diverse reality. Especially influential in Khomeini’s Political wisdom was Plato’s reflection on the virtues of a political ruler.

It is important to note that, as stated above, Plato suggests that States will be governed properly, if philosophers become rulers, or rulers learn philosophy. In his own words Plato states:

Until philosophers rule as kings or those who are now called kings and leading men genuinely and adequately philosophize, that is, until political power and philosophy entirely coincide...cities will have no rest from evils...there can be no happiness, either public or private, in any other city.³⁴

This statement by Plato through the mouth of Socrates, has been the subject of controversy, admiration, praise, and even condemnation in political discussions,

³² Cf. NE. 1280b39–1281a4.

³³ Cf. Pol.1281a4–8.

³⁴ Republic v: 471c-474c.

according to diverse approaches taken by thinkers on the subject of political leadership. However, Plato seem to mean every word of the statement according to the circumstances and experiences of his time. Plato who lived during the reign of tyranny could speak from the example in front of every Athenian of his time, on the evils of Democracy, timocracy, oligarchy and tyranny. For him, in those systems of leadership there was a serious problem of not using reason.

The first and important virtue of a leader, according to Plato, is his love of total wisdom and dislike of money.³⁵ Arranged in the order of importance Plato mentions reason as the first virtue, second is wisdom, third prudence, and fourth Prowess or Bravery, and fifth justice as the virtues particularly of the philosopher king, who has to distribute advantages and disadvantages equally to the society members. These virtues are related under the virtue of reason, under the temperament of shame, as the important virtues that together guide the ruler on the helm of the city.

In Protagoras, in his narration of the creation of the universe through Prometheus and Epimetheus, Plato argues that, those who lack the virtues of justice and shame in the society, should be put to death, since those two virtues are god-given to the human race for its protection and survival. Plato attempts to make shame a kind of accompanying virtue particularly to political leaders. This kind of shame is called intellectual shame by the author of this article.³⁶ This state of mind is different from emotional shame, which is a feeling that accompanies unacceptable action performed by a human being who has the faculty of emotion originating in the human will. Intellectual shame on its part, is the reasonable realization of an impending evil act, and the will's movement to avoid it.

Ayatollah Khomeini was obviously a man of sharp intellect and a man of virtue, especially those virtues of reason, wisdom, prudence and bravery. He consistently showed the virtue of justice, as he always defended the weak of the society, against the shamelessness of the rich and politically powerful elite. History will remember him as a man who was far-sighted for his country and one who used his education for the liberation of his country. His intellectual, moral and religious beliefs were vindicated in front of his opponents and enemies, both from internal and external his loved country.

³⁵ Cf. Ibid. 484b-485a.

³⁶ Soon I am going to publish my Political philosophy entitled: "Are you not Ashamed"? Treating the state of mind called shame, in the life of political leaders.

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